Documenting datasets as a tool for change

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Openness, access, and accessibility encompass both technical and ethical dimensions, as reflected in the conference theme *Accessibility and Citizenship*. These principles aim to democratize inclusive access to knowledge and advocate for community engagement to address pressing societal challenges and more specifically, challenges of the field, such as combating the epistemicide of non-Western ways of knowing, decolonizing digital humanities, and addressing (gender) data gaps. Equity, diversity, and inclusivity are central concerns of the DH—not only as ethical imperatives but also as essential components for producing better, more rigorous scholarship that integrates diverse perspectives.

One practical way to address these challenges is through thorough documentation—particularly of datasets, but also of algorithms and other digital outputs. Documentation can help improve transparency, identify biases or gaps, and provide the context necessary for responsible and equitable reuse, ultimately fostering more inclusive and at the same time more rigorous digital scholarship.

While the FAIR and CARE principles (2021, Egan / Murphy 2022) are widely recognized in digital humanities, Berry (2022) has argued that ethics remains surprisingly under-theorized in the field. This ethical gap is mirrored in machine learning, where calls to address the accountability gap (Raji et al. 2020) have led to practices like auditing algorithms and probing of datasets in the spirit of critical data and code studies. Such efforts have demonstrated their impact, as seen in the retraction of the *80M Tiny Images* dataset and the substantial cleanup of the ImageNet dataset, which resulted in nearly halving the People categories to remove problematic content (Yang et al. 2020, Crawford 2021: 142).

Despite the availability of FAIR data, datasets are rarely reused, a situation largely attributable to insufficient documentation. Properly understanding and effectively reusing a dataset typically requires much more detailed information than the FAIR criteria provide. This shortfall extends beyond technical aspects—crucial for explainability and replicability—to the content level, where issues like data gaps, critical DH, data and code studies come into play. Most data produced in Digital Humanities projects includes some relevant contextual information, typically found in project descriptions. However, it often lacks the comprehensive documentation advocated by initiatives such as Data Feminism (D'Ignazio / Klein 2020), "Datasheets for Datasets" (Gebru et al. 2018/2021) or "Data Envelopes" (Luthra / Eskevich 2024), which aim to establish standards for documenting datasets, particularly in machine learning, to facilitate reuse and ensure ethical practices by addressing issues such as bias.

In recent years, the digital humanities have increasingly embraced critical approaches, including critical DH, critical data studies, and critical code studies. These frameworks draw on the humanities' unique areas of expertise, such as historical source criticism, to develop a digital hermeneutics (Fickers et al. 2022) that critically interrogates data and algorithms. Documentation intersects with these critical concerns in the digital humanities, such as decolonizing the field, addressing data gaps (e.g., the gender data gap), data feminism, explainability, and (reparative) librarianship, by providing a practical, straighforward way of responding to their challenges. For example, documenting historical collections can reveal power structures embedded in datasets and help determine how to address gaps or biases in the data (Koeser / LeBlanc 2024). It is a practical and accessible activity that sheds light on digitization politics (Zaagsma 2023) and identifies where the field lacks data.

Despite its importance, activities such as creating metadata and documenting collections are frequently perceived as menial labor rather than legitimate research contributions (Ross / Pilsch 2022), leading to insufficient incentives for scholars to undertake this time- and resource-intensive work. Recognizing and rewarding this labor is crucial to promoting its adoption, whether through dedicated funding, formal platforms for dataset documentation, or greater acknowledgment of the vital role of this data work (Alvarado 2022) in advancing DH research.

Data paper formats (as in *Journal of Open Humanities Dat*a or *Zeitschrift für digitale Geisteswissenschaften*) address the need for dataset documentation but typically focus on having dataset creators write about their own data. Many datasets, however, remain poorly documented and could benefit from evaluation by external infomediaries (D'Ignazio / Klein 2020: 168-171). While platforms like *Reviews in DH* partially address related issues, they do not fully meet the need for comprehensive dataset documentation. Although the observation that dataset documentation is often inadequate may not be novel, it is striking that this problem persists and requires urgent attention. Without

action to make thorough documentation more attractive and rewarding, this critical issue will remain unaddressed. Unlike technical documentation, which can often be outsourced to AI tools and may quickly become outdated, conceptual documentation of datasets—their construction, conception, and representation—is quite stable over time and thus, a one-time investment that remains relevant and impactful over time.

Documentation connects key areas in digital and computational humanities and has the potential to address various challenges, from data gaps in colonial collections to the replication crisis in machine learning, where inadequate documentation undermines replicability. Furthermore, documentation facilitates explainability in AI by situating data within its broader context. By documenting datasets as a tool for change, we can ensure that data are reusable in meaningful, ethical ways, aligned with well-considered research questions and rigorous research setups. This practice not only enhances diversity, equity, inclusivity, and representation in our field and research agendas but also strengthens the quality of research as clear documentation illuminates the limits and possibilities of a dataset, enabling more precise and rigorous analysis while fostering responsible scholarship. Documenting datasets as a shared task across disciplines and foundational practice in DH not only bridges theoretical and practical concerns in DH but also positions the field to make meaningful contributions to emerging interdisciplinary dialogues on data ethics and sustainability.

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